

FOUR PRACTICAL BUDGET BUILDS

Prices fluctuate, so treat these as philosophies rather than shopping lists.

Setup A: Start for almost nothing

Best for: Solo beginners and pilot episodes.

Use your existing smartphone, wired earphones for checking recordings, a quiet furnished room and an improvised phone stand.

Spend money only after recording several tests. If the voice is clean and intelligible, publish the pilot rather than waiting for better equipment.

Setup B: Roughly ₹7,000–₹12,000

Best for: Serious solo podcasters.

Choose one good USB dynamic microphone – or preferably a USB/XLR hybrid – plus a simple desk stand or arm and wired headphones you already own.

The ATR2100x-USB's current Indian pricing shows that a recognised hybrid microphone can fall within this range before accessories.

This is arguably the sweet spot for a beginner: simple today, expandable tomorrow.

Setup C: Roughly ₹20,000–₹35,000

Best for: Enthusiast solo creators, portable interviewers or video podcasters.

Audio-Technica's ATR2100x-USB, for example, provides USB-C digital output, XLR analogue output and direct headphone monitoring. Audio-Technica India listed it at ₹7,499 when checked for this chapter, although it was temporarily out of stock. The RØDE PodMic USB similarly provides both USB and XLR connectivity, allowing a creator to begin by plugging directly into a computer and later move to an interface-based studio.

That hybrid approach is particularly sensible for beginners who expect their show to grow.

When you need an audio interface

An audio interface accepts microphone signals and sends them to your computer. The number of microphone inputs matters more than glamorous specifications.

For one XLR microphone, buy an interface with at least one proper microphone input. For a two-host show, buy two. Do not buy a single-input interface and assume a cheap splitter will magically create two independently editable tracks.

The Focusrite Scarlett 2i2 4th Gen is an example of the two-input approach, with two microphone preamps, Auto Gain and Clip Safe. Focusrite specifies up to 69dB of gain on the current Scarlett range. Indian online pricing for the 2i2 was

At this level you might choose a better hybrid microphone, quality monitoring headphones, a boom arm and basic acoustic treatment. Alternatively, spend the budget on portability: a recorder, lavalier or wireless system, headphones and storage.

Do not spend the entire amount on the microphone. A ₹25,000 microphone on a ₹500 wobbly table stand is an oddly balanced studio.

Setup D: Roughly ₹45,000 and upwards

Best for: Two-person or small-studio production.

Build around two close-address XLR microphones, a two-input interface or podcast recorder, two headphone feeds, proper stands, cables and room treatment.

A two-input interface alone can cost around ₹20,000 in India, so a genuinely complete two-person system costs substantially more than doubling a cheap solo setup.

For four participants, prioritise four discrete microphone inputs and four separate microphones before spending on decorative studio furniture.

around ₹20,000–₹24,000 when researched in August 2026, illustrating why interfaces can quickly become a major portion of a two-person setup.

For three or four hosts, consider a four-input interface or a dedicated podcast recorder rather than daisy-chaining devices.

Consider a standalone recorder

A laptop is not compulsory. Portable recorders are useful for travel, conferences, outdoor interviews and locations where you do not want to rely on a computer.

The Zoom H1essential, for example, records 32-bit float audio and can serve as a compact field recorder. Zoom's newer podcast-focused PodTrak P4next provides four XLR inputs and can record to microSD while operating from batteries or a portable power source, making it more suited to multi-person field production.

Do not interpret "32-bit float" as permission to ignore microphone placement. It provides enormous headroom for recovering unexpectedly loud or quiet levels, but it cannot remove a barking dog, repair a microphone placed across the room, or restore words masked by traffic. Zoom itself describes 32-bit float as useful for recovering unexpected level spikes in post-production.